Reforming Animal Agriculture Subsidies: A Guide for Advocates

January 2023

Authors: Andrea Polanco & Jo Anderson (Faunalytics)

Contents

Background **4**

Key Findings **6**

Recommendations **6**

Upcoming Reports **7**

Applying These Findings **8**

Behind The Project **8**

Research Team 8

Acknowledgments 8

Research Terminology 8

Research Ethics Statement 8

Method **9**

Participants 9

Results **10**

Setting A Goal 10

Tractability 10

Potential Backfire Effects 10

Specific Goals 11

Shifting Direct Subsidies Towards Alternative Forms Of Agriculture 11

Climate-Friendly Alternatives 11

Independent, Small-Scale Farmers 11

Targeting Key U.S. Subsidy Programs 12

Creating New Funding For Alternative Proteins 13

Challenges With Funding Cultivated Meat 13

Creating Tax Exemptions For Alternative Proteins 14

Lobbying For Language Amendments 15

Enforcing Existing Regulations 16

Antitrust Laws 16

Environmental Regulations 16
Pushing For Plant-Based Food Procurement Policies 17
Increasing The Cost Of Animal Products 18
Other Goals To Consider 19
The Ingredients Of Political Change 20
Stakeholder Collaboration 20
Working Groups 20
Working One-On-One With Stakeholders 21
Lobbying 21
Constituent Lobbying 22
Professional Lobbying 23
Litigation 24
Education 25
Other Tactics 25
Conclusions 26
Direct Subsidies 26
Indirect Subsidies 27
Future Research 28
Caveats & Limitations 28
Supplementary Materials 30
Method Details 30
Pre-Registration 30
Data Collection 30
Thematic Content Coding 30

Background

The global meat and seafood market is an empire worth $867 billion USD worldwide in 2021. This market is dominated by megacorporations like Tyson and JBS which receive billions of dollars in direct subsidies–cash grants, loans, purchases, or other types of financial aid–from their governments. Worldwide, governments provide approximately $540 billion USD annually in direct subsidies to agriculture, with most of these payments going to "Big Ag" (i.e., industrial animal agriculture controlled by a few large corporations, akin to "Big Oil"). The United Nations Food and Agriculture Organization (2021, p. vii) found that "over two-thirds of this support is considered price-distorting and largely harmful to the environment."

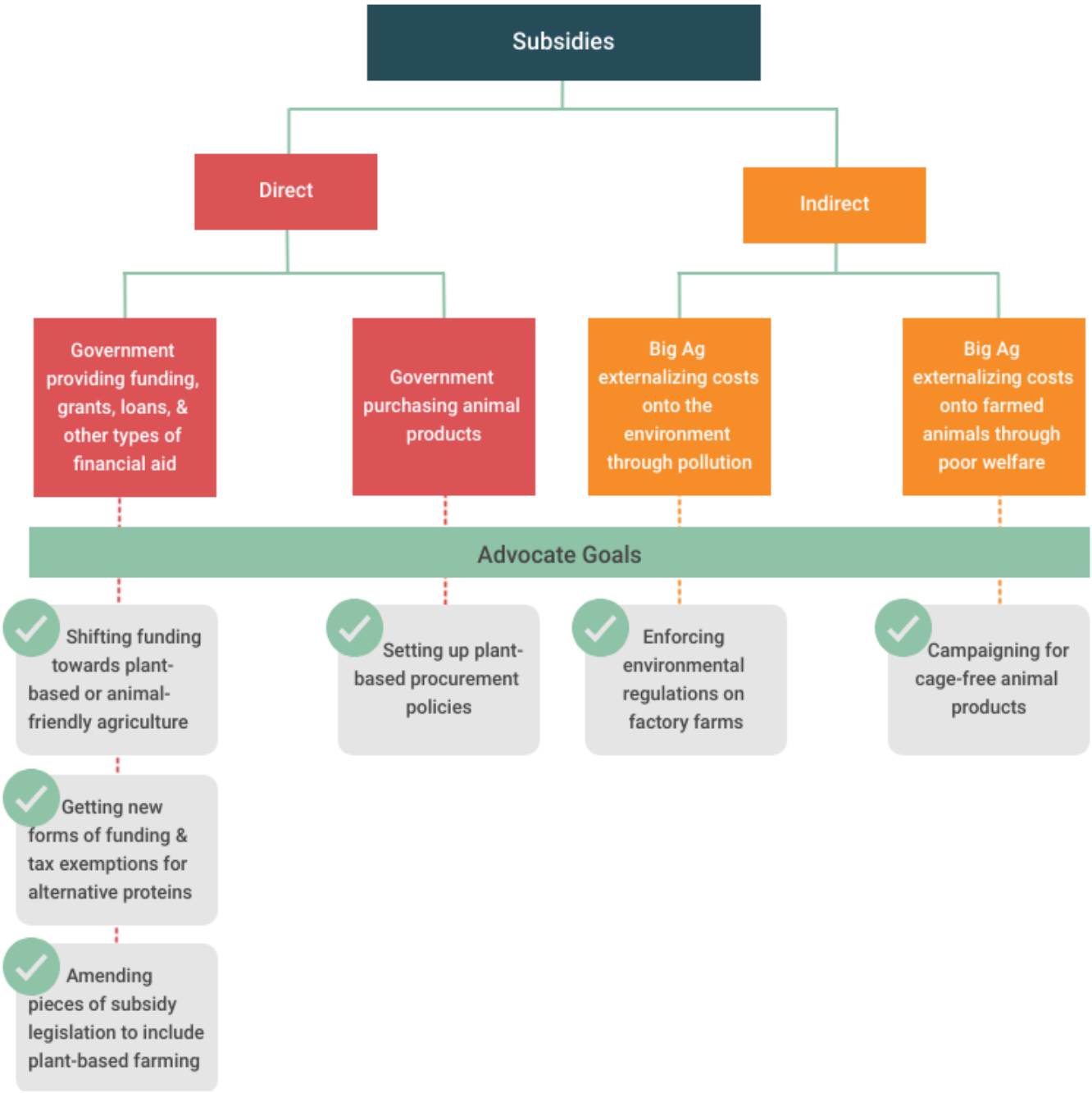
There's another reason why Big Ag dominates the global animal agriculture sector: These companies offload costs or 'externalities' onto human and nonhuman animals by using intensive confinement of animals and exploitative human labor. Such externalities are also referred to as indirect subsidies and they also include other consequences of Big Ag like environmental pollution and public health problems. To put it into perspective, if these costs were actually accounted for in retail prices, consumers would end up paying $1.70 USD more for each dollar of animal product purchased–for example, a gallon of milk would go from $4 to almost $11 in grocery stores (Simon, 2013). But in reality, consumers and society end up paying for these costs indirectly through healthcare costs, environmental pollution, and other problems caused by Big Ag.

Animal agriculture subsidies therefore create an uneven playing field for advocates and plant-based food producers compared to animal-based producers. Given that governments regularly give money and assistance to Big Ag, advocates may question whether vegan outreach or other types of campaigns are sufficient to reform the food system. And how can plant-based food producers compete with animal agriculture when less than 25% of global farm subsidies go to growing fruits and vegetables (Springmann & Freund, 2022)?

The purpose of this study was to understand organizations' successes and challenges in their efforts to shift, reduce, or eliminate animal agriculture subsidies. We interviewed 13 organizations from Brazil, Canada, U.K., and the U.S. to better understand their approaches to reforming animal agriculture subsidies. In doing so, we hope to facilitate knowledge sharing among advocates, and we provide recommendations and lessons learned from a wide range of approaches.

Below in Figure 1, we summarize the two types of subsidies–direct and indirect–and advocates' goals to reform them. Please see *Specific Goals* and *The Ingredients Of Political Change* for details on each goal and how advocates tackle them.

Figure 1. Reforming Animal Agriculture Subsidies



Key Findings

1. **Subsidization of animal agriculture is complicated, and the average person's understanding of subsidies doesn't reflect the reality of how advocates have to approach them**. Tackling subsidies directly is made complicated by Big Ag's immense political influence. For these reasons, advocates have found more success by working to reform farm subsidies, such as by shifting them towards plant-based agriculture, rather than trying to reduce or eliminate government programs that give money to Big Ag. For other approaches, please see *Specific Goals*.
2. **Indirect subsidies are particularly important because they're less obvious: Big Ag saves money by harming people, the environment, and farmed animals.** Some organizations have sued the government and Big Ag companies for failing to comply with environmental and antitrust laws, which is one approach to combating these indirect subsidies. Some advocates also work against them by campaigning for cage-free transitions or other welfare improvements, which requires the industry to invest more money into these changes and thus increases the cost of animal products.
3. **Litigation is an important yet less recognized tool for evening the playing field.** Organizations that have filed a lawsuit against Big Ag companies reported that doing so increased their ability to obtain meetings with politicians, media coverage of the harms of Big Ag, and legislative changes that minimize these harms. Importantly, all this became more feasible after filing a notice of suit, before or without having to enter the courtroom.
4. **Reforming Big Ag subsidies needs to be a collaborative effort between animal advocates, environmental advocates, and farmed animal producers.** Subsidizing Big Ag affects everyone—from non-human animals to small-scale farmers—so many organizations have had the most success in reforming farm subsidies by setting aside their differences and working with stakeholders outside the animal protection movement.

Recommendations

- **Choose a single, specific goal for your organization to be most effective.** There are many ways to target subsidies as they can be direct (i.e., financial aid given to Big Ag by the government) and indirect (i.e., costs of Big Ag that are pushed onto consumers, farmed animals, and the environment). The *Specific Goals* section describes options like expanding subsidy programs to incorporate plant-based agriculture, establishing more plant-based procurement policies, getting tax exemptions for alternative proteins, and suing Big Ag for environmental pollution. However, some advocates we spoke to noted the importance of choosing a single focal goal to avoid spreading your resources too thin.
- **Coordinate and communicate with other groups working on similar issues.** As described above, advocacy organizations can tackle a range of distinct goals to reform Big Ag subsidies and use a variety of methods to achieve them, from lobbying to

litigation. While not all goals will be equally impactful, groups need to ensure that they don't prioritize maximizing their unique impact over the coordination of goals with other groups. Intergroup communication is the most effective way to allocate resources and work alongside one another to avoid conflict or redundancy.

- **Learn about perspectives outside the animal protection movement to communicate with different stakeholders.** Different groups care about reforming Big Ag subsidies for distinct reasons—from environmental to economic. Persuasive data exists for many different arguments so you should pick the information your stakeholder will relate to and that you're comfortable speaking on.
- **In the context of lobbying, train constituent lobbyists to raise awareness of particular issues if possible, while relying on professional lobbyists to amend or write new pieces of subsidy legislation.** Our interviews revealed that constituent lobbyists tend to be more successful than professional lobbyists in getting politicians to understand the harms of Big Ag and obtaining their support. In contrast, professional lobbyists are better trained to expand subsidy legislation or write new legislation that benefits plant-based agriculture. However, professional lobbyists may try to include animal agriculture producers when writing or amending legislation, so advocates need to provide clear objectives to their lobbyists.
- **In the context of alternative proteins, support open-access research of cultivated meat and encourage governments to continue funding plant-based meat innovation.** While both the plant-based and cultivated meat industries would benefit from additional funding, advocates noted that it is particularly important to support open-access work on cultivated meat. The current system of ownership over cultivated cells encourages companies to keep their innovation private. In addition to hindering development, this secrecy allows misinformation about cultivated meat to thrive.

Upcoming Reports

The purpose of this project is to understand how the animal protection movement is working to change subsidies to animal agriculture and how the industry perceives those tactics. This is the first of two reports that will come out of this project.

This first report is a qualitative study where we interviewed different organizations to learn about advocates' strategies to reform farm subsidies. Our second report is a qualitative study where we analyzed animal agriculture industry articles to understand how the industry perceives advocates' strategies to change subsidies to animal agriculture.

Applying These Findings

We understand that reports like this have a lot of information to consider and that acting on research can be challenging. Faunalytics is happy to offer pro bono support to advocates and nonprofit organizations who would like guidance applying these findings to their own work. Please visit our Office Hours or contact us for support.

Behind The Project

Research Team

The report authors are Andrea Polanco and Jo Anderson of Faunalytics. Interview support was provided by Coni Arévalo and Zach Wulderk.

Acknowledgments

This study would not have been possible without the 13 organizations that gave us their time for interviews: Agriculture Fairness Alliance, Earthjustice, Environmental Working Group, Farm Action, Fórum Animal, Friends Of The Earth, The Good Food Institute Brazil, Nation Rising, Public Justice Food Project, Reimagine Agriculture, Rowdy Girl Sanctuary, Stray Dog Institute, and The Vegan Society. We'd also like to thank Cleo Verkuijl (Stockholm Environment Institute) and Ren Springlea (Animal Ask) for their feedback, and an anonymous funder for their generous support of this research.

Research Terminology

At Faunalytics, we strive to make research accessible to everyone. We avoid jargon and technical terminology as much as possible in our reports. If you do encounter an unfamiliar term or phrase, check out the Faunalytics Glossary for user-friendly definitions and examples.

Research Ethics Statement

As with all of Faunalytics' original research, this study was conducted according to the standards outlined in our Research Ethics and Data Handling Policy.

Method

We collected data for this study via semi-structured interviews. Participants were asked a series of questions related to their organization's tactics that have reformed animal agriculture subsidies or that have increased the costs of animal products. The full interview guide and pre-registration are available on the Open Science Framework.

Participants

We interviewed 15 individuals (representing a total of 13 organizations) who were currently working at an organization that has tried to reform animal agriculture subsidies or increase the cost of animal products. This was a targeted sample informed by research into current advocacy initiatives, and some participants were suggested by colleagues in other organizations.

- Eight participants were from eight different organizations in the U.S.: Agriculture Fairness Alliance, Earthjustice, Environmental Working Group, Farm Action, Friends Of The Earth, Public Justice Food Project, Rowdy Girl Sanctuary, and Stray Dog Institute.
- Three participants were from two different organizations in Brazil: Fórum Animal and Good Food Institute Brazil.
- Three participants were from two different organizations in Canada: Nation Rising and Reimagine Agriculture.
- One participant was from an organization in the U.K.: The Vegan Society.

Although the study invitation noted that interview questions could be translated and answered over email, all participants opted to participate in an oral English interview.

Results

Setting A Goal

This section describes the varied goals that can be involved with reforming animal agriculture subsidies, as described to us by our participants. As you'll read below, these goals are shaped by the complexity of subsidies and the immense power and influence of Big Ag: They have to account for resistance from politicians and the conflicts of interest between the government and Big Ag. Because advocates noted that Big Ag's power was the biggest obstacle to reducing or eliminating animal agriculture subsidies, most organizations took an indirect approach, working on reforming subsidies instead.

Tractability

Organizations also focus on reforming subsidies instead of trying to reduce or eliminate them altogether because agriculture funding is sometimes limited, so asking the government to provide new forms of funding may be less tractable than asking for changes to existing programs. For example, the Farm Bill, the key piece of U.S. federal legislation governing how much funding goes towards different food and agriculture programs, is estimated to cost $428 billion USD across its 5-year span (USDA, 2018). According to some participants, the Farm Bill is unlikely to receive additional funding, which is why U.S. organizations tend to focus on smaller amendments to this bill.

While most organizations we interviewed focused on reforming agriculture subsidies, this approach hasn't been politically feasible in some countries (e.g., Brazil). In this case, advocates may need to focus on alternatives like increasing the costs of animal products instead. Most importantly, advocates must first understand the political climate of a country before starting any subsidy campaign as the intensity of these political obstacles will vary between countries.

Potential Backfire Effects

A recent report from Animal Ask (2022) also highlights potential harmful consequences of reducing or eliminating animal agriculture subsidies: In New Zealand, the government eliminated subsidies for economic reasons and this reduced the number of farmed sheep, but it increased the number of farmed cows and chickens. The authors cautioned that more economic research is needed to fully understand the impact of reducing or eliminating animal agriculture subsidies on the number of animals farmed for human consumption.

When reading about different goals below, advocates should keep in mind that any link in the chain of producing an animal product–from financing a farm to sourcing ingredients for production–can be targeted when reforming animal agriculture subsidies. Most importantly, disrupting these stages of production may delay or prevent companies from delivering the final

animal product to consumers, though advocates should carefully consider the tractability and potential consequences of their chosen goal.

Specific Goals

Shifting Direct Subsidies Towards Alternative Forms Of Agriculture

Direct subsidies include cash payments to farmers or companies like loans and grants. Some advocacy organizations are working to shift these funds from industrialized animal agriculture towards more animal-friendly and sustainable forms of agriculture, including alternative proteins (i.e., plant-based and cultivated meat), or small-scale agriculture farmers.

Climate-Friendly Alternatives

Organizations we interviewed tended to focus on environmental arguments rather than public health or animal welfare when asking for a shift in subsidies. Though it depends on a country's circumstances, there are several good reasons for this approach: First, there's a lot of existing, persuasive data on the environmental impact of animal agriculture compared to other options. Also, many governments already have programs and policies in place to improve the environmental impact of agriculture or at least work toward reducing their overall climate impact, so it's reasonable to ask the government to improve the alignment between their subsidies and their existing environmental goals.

However, it can be difficult to ask for policy reforms based on environmental reasons when a country's government hasn't acknowledged the large impact of animal agriculture on carbon emissions. For example, the Canadian government plans to reduce agriculture emissions by only 1% to meet their 2030 emissions' reduction target, while they plan to reduce oil and gas emissions by 40-45% (Government of Canada, 2022). One of our participants noted the difficulty of "convinc[ing] people to divest subsidies if we're not counting carbon emissions, if there's such a lack of knowledge in the general public about the reasons to move away from intensive animal agriculture."

Additionally, advocates need to be careful about how climate-based initiatives are presented, as they could cause more animal suffering if subsidies are shifted from the high-emissions beef and dairy industries to lower-emissions industries like chicken (Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations, 2013), resulting in more smaller-bodied animals being farmed. This is known as the "small-animal replacement problem," but it can be avoided if advocates work towards shifting subsidies from factory farming to plant-based agriculture and alternative proteins instead of from one group of farmed animals to another.

Independent, Small-Scale Farmers

Some organizations we spoke to are also working to shift funds or subsidies from large-scale agriculture companies towards smaller-scale, independently-owned agriculture operations. Because global farm subsidies tend to go to the largest farms (UN Food and Agriculture Organization, 2021, or see EWG, 2022 for the U.S.), animal advocates should support policy reforms that give more money to small, plant-based farmers instead. Doing so will incentivize

existing plant-based farmers to stay in the industry and it may motivate farmed animal producers to transition to plant-based agriculture instead.

Targeting Key U.S. Subsidy Programs

U.S. organizations tend to focus on amending the Farm Bill, which will be renewed for another five years in 2023, because this piece of federal legislation dictates where direct subsidies end up. Given the time sensitivity and the impact that reforming the Farm Bill may have on U.S. subsidies, we have outlined several U.S. subsidy programs below that participants identified as important for awareness or reform.

First, insurance programs subsidize farmers by, for instance, giving money to producers who lose profits or crop yield due to poor weather conditions. This is problematic because in the U.S. most crop insurance subsidies go to commodity crops (i.e., crops grown in large volumes) like corn and soybeans, most of which is grown as feed for farmed animals rather than human consumption (EWG, 2022). Consequently, farmers who instead grow specialty crops like fruits and vegetables for human consumption have a harder time obtaining crop insurance. This in turn reduces their chances of getting bank loans because banks won't give loans to farmers without an insurance policy. In other words, insurance programs favor farmers who grow animal feed over fruits and vegetables, resulting in an uneven playing field for plant-based food producers.

Some interviewees indicated that reforming insurance programs can be an uphill battle because *how* farmers use the insurance money is currently untracked, which makes it difficult to meaningfully restrict or redirect its use and can even enable fraud (e.g., some farmers have been caught lying about crop damage to get insurance: Marzen, 2013). Additionally, Animal Ask (2022) cited some economic modelling studies predicting that removing subsidies for commodity crops may not reduce the number of farmed animals and could actually do the opposite. The Greenfield Project (2018) had a similar conclusion: Removing crop subsidies won't impact farmed animals because it won't change the retail price of animal products for consumers. Therefore, while it's important that advocates understand the impact insurance companies have in subsidizing Big Ag, reforming insurance programs may not be a good use of advocates' resources.

Second, programs providing ad hoc payments, such as the Market Facilitation Program (MFP) and Coronavirus Food Assistance Program (CFAP), are worthy of scrutiny. These programs compensate industries for revenue losses due to unique events like trade disputes between countries and COVID-19. According to our participants, these programs tend to be wasteful: farmers can receive payments for the same reason more than once, and most grants go to the wealthiest farmers (EWG, 2022). To address the issues with this system, U.S. Senator Booker has introduced a new bill that would remove this program for factory farms, among other policies, and instead require Big Ag companies to prepare for disasters and to pay for any costs associated with culling animals as a result. Some advocates we spoke to said that ad hoc payment programs are difficult to reform as—like insurance—they tend to only cover commodity

crops, and these advocates perceived less opportunity to reform commodity crop programs. However, Senator Booker's new bill presents advocates with an opportunity to lobby members of Congress to support it. See the *Lobbying* section below to learn more.

Additionally, several participants noted the importance of reforming checkoff programs, which collect money from farmers and producers and pay it out in grants for market research and advertising. The dairy industry's infamous "Got Milk?" campaign is one example of a checkoff program at work, as is the beef industry's campaign against improving labeling standards for U.S. food products. They're called "checkoff reform" programs because farmers had to check off a box to opt into supporting these initiatives when filling out forms in the 1930s, but today they are controversial because of low transparency and a perception that they prioritize corporate farms (Farm Action, 2021; Farm Bill Law Enterprise, 2020). There have also been cases of fraud.

More generally, advocates we interviewed indicated that federal-level subsidies may have a bigger impact than state-level ones because there are more funds available at the federal level. However, advocates can build momentum and raise awareness at the state level, and some states' legislators may be more receptive to change than federal legislators.

Creating New Funding For Alternative Proteins

Rather than shifting current animal agriculture subsidies towards alternative proteins, some organizations we interviewed instead advocate for new or additional funding for alternative proteins, including cultivated meat (meat made from animal cells).

According to participants, these tactics provide more opportunities to collaborate with companies that also produce animal products, which carries certain advantages. One participant indicated that Big Ag companies already have well-established relationships with politicians, which makes it easier for alternative protein advocates to be part of a success. However, Big Ag companies are less likely to collaborate with alternative protein advocates who are trying to reform subsidies that benefit animal agriculture, so advocates may have to choose one strategy over another.

Participants noted that working to shift subsidies away from animal agriculture—versus expanding funding to include both—may also lead to retaliation from Big Ag: for instance, demanding that the government place even higher taxes on alternative proteins. Some alternative protein companies avoid these challenges by collaborating with animal agriculture companies rather than advocating against them.

Challenges With Funding Cultivated Meat

There are also unique challenges associated with funding cultivated meat per se. Because it's still a new industry, there's a lack of public understanding of what it is, and it has yet to be regulated.

Canada is a strong example of some of those challenges. Despite Canada investing over $30 million USD in plant-based food research and$100 million USD in plant-based development

(Good Food Institute, 2022), cultivated meat research and development is lagging behind. According to an interviewee, cultivated meat companies struggle to take off in Canada because there are fewer education programs, job training opportunities, and investors compared to the U.S. Canadian companies are also likely to sell their products in the U.S., so needing approval from the Food and Drug Administration incentivizes cultivated meat companies to set up in the U.S. instead.

Cultivated meat would also benefit from funding for open-access research. Currently, cultivated meat companies are financially motivated to keep their processes private as this gives them a competitive advantage. Generally, companies can only obtain cultivated cells by working with universities or other companies that will then own (or at least potentially own) the intellectual property (IP) rights for their product. If there were instead a public cell bank where companies could purchase the cells or materials they need, then these companies would be able to experiment freely without worrying that someone else would own the rights to what they create, which would encourage faster development.

The secrecy of cultivated meat companies could also cause public mistrust because the public doesn't know what these companies are doing. Thus, advocates may wish to support funding for open-access research and development to reduce misinformation. Educational campaigns can also combat misinformation. This may be particularly useful if they target funders and politicians to clarify what cultivated meat is and how it differs from plant-based meat. One organization recommended creating parallels between a government's initiatives in the plant-based industry and the potential for cultivated meat to bring similar benefits.

Creating Tax Exemptions For Alternative Proteins

In countries like Brazil, alternative protein companies pay more taxes than companies producing animal products, leading some organizations to focus on obtaining tax exemptions for alternative proteins.

The first step in undertaking this type of work is to establish national food regulations for alternative proteins if they aren't already in place in a given country, so that they can receive a tax code. One participant gave an example:

> *If the product doesn't have this [tax code] number then the product is categorized as something that they call "other." [...] Before I can ask for better taxes for a plant-based burger, "plant-based burger" needs to exist in the nomenclature for taxes.*

The same participant noted that the tax system is "global and very hard to change," so this isn't an easy approach. Indeed, global coordination is key here because countries typically follow the World Customs Organization for coding food products. In other words, having alternative proteins included in the World Customs Organization would be a win for alternative protein companies around the world. But even before that occurs, advocates can still help establish national food regulations for alternative proteins, albeit noting that countries may differ in their quality or nutritional standards of food products.

Once regulations and tax codes are in place, then alternative protein companies can seek a tax exemption for their products. This advocate recommended that a coalition of multiple plant-based companies should lead these efforts. For example, the U.S.-based Plant Based Food Association is one such group. Once an association is formed, they can submit an application to the government requesting a tax exemption for their alternative protein products.

Although one advocate suggested that a coalition of plant-based companies could have more leverage with the government if it includes companies like Tyson that primarily produce animal products but have a plant-based division, we would advise groups to carefully consider the potential economic and animal welfare consequences of partnering with Big Ag.

Lobbying For Language Amendments

The exact language used in subsidy legislation (e.g., the U.S. Farm Bill) can be very impactful as it governs who and what can be considered for financial aid. For this reason, advocates will often lobby for small changes in legislation language: for instance, rewording direct subsidy programs to include plant-based farmers, plant-based farm transitions, and farmers from marginalized communities.

Some agriculture subsidies exclude plant-based farmers who grow 'specialty crops,' which include fruits, vegetables, and nuts. For example, as noted previously, disaster relief programs are typically only given to farmed animal producers and commodity crop farmers (with those crops going to farmed animals' feed), so advocates may be able to lobby for language revisions to these programs to include plant-based farmers (see *Lobbying* below). Likewise, advocates may be able to use the booming consumer market for pulses (e.g., lentils and beans; Joshi & Rao, 2016) to persuade the government to align more subsidies to support pulse growers as pulses are now seen as premium food products.

Advocates we spoke to noted that subsidizing fruits, vegetables, and nuts will lower the price of these products for consumers, thereby making them more broadly accessible. This is especially important considering the issue of diet inclusivity: For example, Black, Indigenous, and People of The Global Majority (BIPGM) are more likely to be lactose intolerant than white people (Gaskin & Ilich, 2009). That said, while lower prices are associated with increased fruit and vegetable consumption, they don't appear to reduce the consumption of animal products (Cornelsen et al., 2014). For this reason, increasing subsidies for plant-based foods may not be the most effective intervention to make immediate improvements to animal lives (Animal Ask, 2022). At the same time, this approach may provide a foot in the door to other, more impactful actions in the long term, while having immediate equity benefits by improving access to affordable plant-based foods.

Indeed, animal advocates should consider how marginalized communities are also negatively impacted by the food system, as advocating for social justice can benefit non-human animals too. Reducing or eliminating factory farms and slaughterhouses will not only reduce farmed animal suffering, but would also reduce human labor exploitation. By extension, food accessibility for marginalized communities and just transitions for farmed animal producers must

be part of the same conversation. As one example of how to join these related topics, the Agriculture Fairness Alliance (AFA) incorporates racial and equity issues into their work reforming animal agriculture subsidies. AFA is working to make loans and grants for any vegan-backed policy changes to be more accessible to marginalized groups like women, veterans, and BIPGM farmers, considering their long history of discrimination by the government (e.g., Black farmers in the U.S. are less likely to get subsidies than white farmers: EWG, 2017).

It may also be possible to expand other subsidy programs to include an option for farmed animal producers to transition into plant-based agriculture. In our current food system, mitigating and avoiding animal diseases and zoonotic (animal to human) diseases is an important part of the conversation, which advocates may be able to leverage. Even if farmers are financially compensated by their insurance company after killing all their chickens due to avian flu, they may be hesitant to continue in the chicken industry for concerns that this experience will happen again. If legislation such as AFA's Farm and Ranch Mobility Solutions (FARMS) Act can be passed, it will offer animal producers an exit strategy, transitioning them into plant-based agriculture rather than putting them out of business.

Enforcing Existing Regulations

Subsidies to animal agriculture can also be indirect: Big Ag reaps financial benefits by not having to pay for or offset the environmental damage caused by factory farms and the feed grown for farmed animals. In some countries like the U.S. and Brazil, laws already exist to theoretically address this, so advocacy organizations can work to eliminate these indirect subsidies by asking governments to enforce existing environmental laws.

Corporate producers have also been caught engaging in anti-competitive behavior by fixing prices of animal products to increase profits. Here too, the primary strategy to address this issue is calling on governments to enforce existing laws—in this case, antitrust laws.

Antitrust Laws

In a free market, prices of animal products should fluctuate with consumer demand for them. However, Big Ag companies have been found guilty of price-fixing and purposely limiting the supply of animal products to artificially inflate prices for consumers.

In instances like this, advocates can and do bring antitrust lawsuits against animal agriculture companies. However, this takes substantial time and resources, so it will also be important to support policy recommendations that are currently under development for the U.S.'s Federal Trade Commission, aimed at making future price-fixing cases easier to prosecute.

Environmental Regulations

Despite animal agriculture causing approximately 20% of global greenhouse gas emissions (Xu et al., 2021), factory farms are sometimes exempt from environmental regulations (U.S. Environmental Protection Agency, 2017). Big Ag companies also use the lack of strong emission-estimating methods to justify their avoidance of those regulations.

Some governments also exempt factory farms from reporting their emissions (e.g., under the Comprehensive Environmental Response and Compensation and Liability Act in the U.S.). Advocates have countered these tactics by using lawsuits to enforce government regulation of animal agriculture operations and to require factory farms to track and report toxic levels of air and water emissions.

Because cows are the largest source of animal agriculture's greenhouse gas emissions, making up 65% of emissions (Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations, 2013), both the supply and demand sides of the beef and dairy industries can be targeted through an environmental lens. However, there are risks to doing so if the goal is to improve animal welfare because Big Ag can counter with solutions that work from an environmental perspective, yet do nothing to help animals.

Big Ag's latest green-washing narrative focuses on structural reforms, like methane digesters, which capture the methane produced by cow manure so that it can be converted and sold as an energy source (described by the industry as biogas). But this approach promotes more factory farming and environmental pollution by financially incentivizing farmers. Through direct subsidies intended to support environmental improvements, cattle farmers are given financial assistance to install methane digesters, which may consequently increase the number of farmed animals because their methane is now profitable to farmers (e.g., producers can now sell biogas back to the government).

For example, on top of the money dairy farmers can get per gallon of milk, they can get half again for animal waste (Smith, 2021). A farmer told a participant we interviewed how it's "a gold rush right now for factory-farmed gas and [he] never imagined the day that he would get paid as much for animal waste as he did for meat, but that day has basically come." What was once thought of as an excess byproduct is now being indirectly marketed and monetized as a co-product with devastating effects for the environment and surrounding communities (and is now being used by pig producers too; Union Of Concerned Scientists, 2022).

While biogas is now a major concern for many animal advocates and some organizations have pursued litigation against producers that use it for greenwashing, other participants suggested that it may already be too late to effectively work against it because of how established it's become, and the lack of environmental impact data available to build a case. These comments point to the importance of advocates identifying new industry developments before they become entrenched and continuing to pursue necessary intermediate goals like forcing industry to track and report their environmental impact.

Pushing For Plant-Based Food Procurement Policies

Government food procurement refers to food purchased by the government of a region, which has been discussed in recent years as a promising strategy for shifting consumption patterns at scale (e.g., Swensson et al., 2022). In many countries, the government is one of the largest purchasers of agricultural products. For instance, the U.S. government spends more than $3 billion a year on food (USDA, 2022). This practice incentivizes animal agriculture producers to

overproduce animal products because they know the federal government will generally buy the excess. Advocates are working to reshape these practices by lobbying for government policies that focus on purchasing more plant-based foods and offering plant-based meals in government buildings and/or other government-supported institutions like public hospitals or schools.

Various arguments can be used when advocating for plant-based food procurement policies. They can be framed as necessary to support many governments' inclusivity goals, in that people from some religious and cultural groups can't or choose not to eat animal-based proteins. Environmental arguments can also be persuasive, especially for more progressive cities or regions: for instance, many groups will phrase these policies in terms of "climate-friendly food" purchasing. The Good Food Purchasing Program in the U.S. is one such example (also discussed in Faunalytics, 2022). Advocates may also want to make connections between their goals and existing food policies: For example, Canada's recommended food guide is mostly plant-based, so Canadian advocates can ask the government to improve the alignment between their procurement policies and their established food guide. Lastly, advocates can argue for better procurement policies as a way to support specialty crop farmers as the government tends to be a major client for farmers, and politicians are generally sympathetic to helping independent farmers rather than corporate-run farms.

Schools can also be major food purchasers: One participant noted that schools are one of the largest purchasers from U.S. cities and counties. However, institutions typically want to quantify the difference their policies make, with environmental impact being the most difficult to report. For this reason, some advocates we spoke to don't recommend encouraging schools to track their emissions because it will be too labor-intensive.

Increasing The Cost Of Animal Products

Changing direct animal agriculture subsidies isn't necessarily feasible in some countries due to their current political climate. In those cases, some advocates instead work to increase the cost of animal products through producer-facing campaigns like transitioning barns to a cage-free model for egg-laying hens. While most advocates may not consider this type of work through the lens of animal agriculture subsidies, it's a way to bring some of the costs of animal products back into the financial realm rather than allowing them to be hidden from the public in the form of animal suffering behind closed doors. At the same time, it's important to note that in a world where food prices are rising (World Bank Group, 2022) and where one in three people don't have access to adequate food (Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations, 2021), some consumers can't afford to pay more for cage-free products, so cheaper plant-based alternatives should be highlighted too.

When animal advocacy organizations ask egg producers to go cage-free, it's crucial to establish trust with them first because there's often a negative portrayal of animal advocates from a farmed animal producer's perspective. To overcome negative perceptions and trust issues, organizations we interviewed had their veterinarians and animal welfare scientists talk to egg producers about small-scale animal welfare practices that could benefit those producers (e.g.,

how to identify feather-plucking in their flock), and eventually open cage-free discussions. This is a slow process of trust-building: Obtaining cage-free commitments from egg producers could take a year or more. One organization we spoke to found a way to bring egg producers on board more quickly by creating a map of the housing systems used by egg producers in the country, which then allowed them to publicize their cage-free products whereas previously they may not have gotten public "credit" for it.

One participant noted that it's important for advocates to be transparent with farmed animal producers here in that transitioning to cage-free will initially cost them more money. Advocates we interviewed lessened this blow by emphasizing how cages are a relic of the past and that consumers are eager for higher-welfare animal products.

In addition to egg producers, advocates also need companies to pledge to go cage-free in order to be successful, or cage-free egg producers may have difficulty selling their products if they are higher priced. Here, advocates should communicate to company management that signing a cage-free pledge is done on behalf of the entire company and the animals, not just themselves. Doing so will help increase accountability and avoid a situation in which an employee turnover means the commitment is forgotten. However, one interviewee mentioned that the culture of companies being transparent about their cage-free policy isn't as common in countries like Brazil as it is in the U.S. Without a public commitment it may be difficult to ensure follow-through, so advocates in countries where companies don't flaunt their social responsibility as often as the U.S. may wish to consider whether campaigning for higher-welfare commitments is the best strategy for them.

Other Goals To Consider

There are other tactics that can increase the cost of animal products, such as divestment (when companies such as banks cease to invest in Big Ag) or introducing a meat tax. We haven't covered them in this report because they had only been pursued for a short time by the two organizations that mentioned them. However, it's worth noting that one group didn't pressure a bank to divest from animal agriculture because they felt that they could be retaliated against by both agribusinesses and the bank. In contrast, the group that was working on a meat tax in the U.K. dropped this campaign for practical reasons after the U.K. left the European Union.

Both approaches have been studied by Animal Ask, who concluded that these tactics aren't worth pursuing. We recommend that readers considering these approaches review their reports on divestment and meat taxes for more information.

The Ingredients Of Political Change

This section describes the different ways advocates can pursue the goals above. Please note that these approaches are not mutually exclusive and that some advocates may choose to use multiple approaches to achieve their goal.

Before engaging in any of the approaches below, it is crucial to find out what's already being done at the municipal, state, or federal level in your country for your chosen goal: Are there existing groups you can support rather than starting your own?

Existing or new organizations working on changing the food system in the same country should choose and communicate their goals with each other, such that resources are allocated effectively across different goals. Each group can specialize while still working cooperatively, just as Big Ag does: They have industry-specific lobbying groups that work on different sectors, such as the National Cattlemen's Beef Association and the National Pork Producers Council in the U.S. Advocates we interviewed suggested that the animal protection movement can do the same, with different organizations each focusing on different but related subsidy programs or policies. As one participant put it, "Do one thing and do it really, really well." While there are groups already working to reform some subsidy programs and policies, in any country there is likely room for organizations to tackle other aspects of subsidization—because as we saw in the *Goals* section, there are many ways of doing so.

Regardless of the goal and method chosen, advocates should have realistic expectations. Political change is slow and driven by many competing factors. We encourage advocates to focus their efforts on achievable yet meaningful wins–working incrementally toward the systemic, global change we want to see.

Stakeholder Collaboration

The food system involves many different key players. Reforming subsidies therefore requires working with everyone affected to understand their needs and guide them through changes: consumers, farmers and producers, companies, policymakers, and advocates.

Working Groups

Some organizations have successfully used working groups to bring together people from different parts of the food system to discuss changes to the food system, including subsidy reforms.

In a group like this, there will naturally be disagreements and differing values. For example, advocacy groups will sometimes view the various potential solutions to factory farming as competing with one another, such as regenerative agriculture and alternative protein development. To overcome this tension, interviewees suggested that workgroup participants need to keep in mind their shared goals (e.g., transforming animal agriculture) and find ways to work toward them without undermining one another's specific work.

Moral disagreements, such as between groups pursuing incremental change versus abolition of current practices, can also be counterproductive when trying to encourage collaboration among stakeholders. For instance, it can be difficult to find mutually acceptable language for proposed policy changes. Some interviewees recommended that if a working group includes advocates from different moral frameworks, then the hosting organization should be impartial, not directly engaged in any type of advocacy. However, setting a specific goal for the working group in advance may also help determine who should be invited as contributors.

Working One-On-One With Stakeholders

When working with different stakeholders individually, advocates should keep their goal consistent, but consider adapting their message framing to match their audience's values. For instance, is a particular stakeholder most likely to care about the economic, environmental, animal protection, or social justice implications of helping farmers transition to plant-based agriculture?

Despite attempts to adapt our messaging, some stakeholders, especially animal agriculture producers, may perceive advocates as "anti-farming" and reject speaking to them. Interviewees noted that it's possible to challenge these negative perceptions if approached carefully. As noted in the *Goals* section, building a relationship of trust is important, and part of that can be accomplished by emphasizing shared goals, like ensuring good welfare for farmed animals and workers.

Once the conversation is started, these negative perceptions can also be addressed with positive framing, such as explaining how the approach or innovation will help agriculture industries or boost the economy, rather than harming farmers, the industry, or the economy. It may be particularly important to distinguish small farmers from corporations, pointing out how reforming subsidies can benefit small-scale farmers too because most subsidies currently go towards companies.

Finally, whatever message or framing you use (e.g., environmental, animal welfare, public health, labor rights), advocates should prepare in advance and look for data on their chosen issue. While a person can be openly vegan or vegetarian and have these conversations, veganism or animal rights shouldn't be the main argument with a stakeholder who has different values. It's also important to remember not to lie or make an argument you don't believe in.

Lobbying

The development of subsidies and their dissemination are executed by government officials through pieces of legislation such as the Farm Bill. For this reason, some organizations focus heavily on influencing the decisions of politicians when reforming subsidies.

Broadly speaking, there are two types of lobbying to be aware of: constituent and professional. Constituent lobbying is when constituents—members of the public in that voting district—meet with politicians to push for legislative or policy change. Unlike constituent lobbying, professional lobbyists are paid to speak to a politician on behalf of a group or individual.

Some of our participants' recommendations are applicable to both types of lobbying. For example, similar to collaborating with other stakeholders, advocates will likely be more effective in delivering their message or getting a bill signed if they can develop relationships with politicians across the political spectrum. However, it's important to keep in mind the need for positive framing, which may differ slightly with different politicians. For instance, one organization noted that when discussing U.S. Senator Booker's proposed Farm System Reform Act with politicians, advocates should focus on how this bill supports farmers staying in business rather than the animal welfare or environmental impact of a factory farm moratorium.

It can also be impactful to provide politicians with an example of the change advocates want to see, by inviting farmers who have transitioned to higher-welfare or plant-based agriculture. A single positive example like this can help demonstrate to politicians, especially those who are pro-animal agriculture, that farmed animal producers can and do change their method of farming. Finding farmers to act as positive examples may seem challenging, but advocates can contact transitioning programs like Rowdy Girl Sanctuary or MFA's Transfarmation Program to obtain more information on farmed animal producers who have switched to plant-based farming or even ask local farmed animal producer groups whether anyone has adopted higher-welfare housing for their animals.

In addition to demonstrating the realism of their goal, advocates should demonstrate demand for it if possible. Using data or even real-life examples, advocates can mention the number of farmers who, for instance, would like to transition to plant-based agriculture.

Lastly, while advocates should be aware that municipalities may not have the power to determine farmed animal welfare standards, establishing rapport with municipal politicians may be a useful stepping stone toward higher-level change for animals (Faunalytics, 2022). In some countries, municipalities may have more direct power, but even if not, they may be able to influence the level of government above them on behalf of their constituents.

Constituent Lobbying

There was a consensus in our interviews that constituent lobbying is more effective than professional lobbying in getting politicians to listen to advocates' messages. Previous research supports this belief: A study found that state legislators who were contacted by their constituents were more likely to support a bill than state legislators who weren't (Bergan & Cole, 2015).

Interviewees said that small local groups may seem more credible than large organizations on the same issue. For instance, they noted that politicians will take the environmental pollution caused by animal agriculture more seriously if they hear the message from their constituents versus environmental groups. Advocates noted that this strategy has potential to be large-scale if constituents across different regions and even countries are meeting with politicians and advocating for the same thing. Even in rural districts where politicians are very protective of agriculture, the number of farmers is actually very small, they just have powerful lobbies behind them. The advocate who mentioned this said that rural legislators would be swayed if everyone else spoke up about the issue.

However, there are challenges associated with constituent lobbying. Interviewees mentioned that there can be a months-long wait to meet with politicians in some regions. In addition, volunteers may feel underqualified or intimated to speak with politicians.

With respect to the challenge of volunteers feeling underqualified, organizations should emphasize that volunteers who take on the constituent lobbyist role don't need to be experts on all the different issues, they just need to advocate for change. Nonetheless, one advocate recommended giving volunteers a foundation in the issues by having them attend any existing government-hosted events about agriculture legislation, such as the Farm Bill listening sessions in the U.S. Advocates can visit their country's agriculture department website to see whether this is an option. If not, organizations themselves may wish to record a similar overview for volunteers, with a live question period at the end.

Organizations can also create lay-friendly policy briefs or lobbying materials for their volunteers, giving them speaking points on different issues. The organization or volunteers can then research each politician's values (e.g., via public statements or voting records) and pick speaking points that align with their values. Organizations we interviewed also helped empower volunteers by sharing the past experiences of other constituent lobbyists, in addition to providing mock meetings and training modules.

Professional Lobbying

Big Ag spends millions of dollars on lobbying efforts and political campaigns. For example, the meat conglomerate Tyson Foods has spent more than $25 million USD lobbying the government since 2000. At a high level, it's clear that hiring lobbyists influences legislation, yet success rates of professional lobbyists are unknown because they're difficult to measure objectively (Animal Ask, 2022; Campos & Giovannoni, 2013).

If they can afford it, advocacy organizations might choose to use professional lobbyists over constituent lobbyists for several reasons. First, professional lobbyists are more knowledgeable than constituent lobbyists on how to pass certain pieces of legislation or language amendments because they are well-versed and trained in politics, including how to talk to politicians and their staff. This may be particularly important when writing a bill or working on language amendments, whereas constituent lobbyists may be more persuasive in influencing a politician's votes. Professional lobbyists, who often have existing relationships with politicians, may also be better able to get meetings with politicians than constituents.

Advocates need to remember, though, that professional lobbyists are typically aiming for a 'win' at any cost. As a result, they may try to make compromises that would be unacceptable to the organizations who hired them unless they're given very clear guidance. One participant gave us the example that professional lobbyists might try to expand a proposed program for plant-based agriculture to include farmed animal producers. While this inclusion would make it more likely to pass, it would further subsidize animal agriculture. Advocates need to watch out for this and make their goals and boundaries clear when hiring a lobbyist.

Litigation

As mentioned in the *Enforcing Existing Regulations* section, some organizations engage in environmental or antitrust lawsuits (litigation) against animal agriculture companies to hold them accountable for causing environmental damage and engaging in anti-competitive business practices.

But perhaps most importantly, interviewees emphasized that litigation can be used as a tool outside the courtroom to put pressure on animal agriculture industries. For example, in the U.S. and other countries, the organization planning to pursue litigation is required to notify the defendant company that they will be taking legal action against them—that is, provide them with a "notice of suit." Once these notices have been filed, it becomes much easier to obtain media coverage and meetings with government officials. This is what happened in one U.S. community: after filing a lawsuit against a slaughterhouse for water contamination, community members were able to get meetings with politicians and be featured in national media, which resulted in the town getting clean water, and new legislative changes on water protection. These 'wins' all happened without completing the actual lawsuit, which would have been more time-consuming and expensive.

Litigation can also build upon itself, making it easier to pursue additional cases. For instance, in a recently-settled case, Animal Legal Defense Fund sued Hormel Corporation for misleading use of the word "natural." Although that case started in 2016 and only just resolved in 2022, in the meantime it spurred several more false advertising lawsuits against Big Ag companies, partly because it resulted in a judgment allowing nonprofit organizations to sue companies on behalf of the public for false marketing. Importantly, these cases have also resulted in public admissions from companies about the unnatural methods they use to confine and inseminate animals, which allowed attorneys to demonstrate that companies use the word natural to mislead consumers and hide common practices used in factory farming.

While all lawsuits take time and effort, as the example above shows, interviewees noted that antitrust lawsuits can be particularly challenging because they often require whistleblower information: an individual on the inside who is willing to provide evidence that price-fixing or other anti-competitive practices are occurring. This is necessary because, while states have subpoena power to obtain information from companies that they don't want to provide, nonprofit organizations don't.

In sum, while litigation is challenging and advocates should be mindful of which are more challenging than others, "wins" aren't necessarily achieved in the courtroom alone. Lawsuits provide many opportunities to convey information to the public, influence interpretation of law in a way that allows for future action against corporations, and pressure companies directly.

Education

The advocates we spoke to indicated that the public—including even farmers and animal advocates—aren't very aware of animal agriculture subsidies and their impact. For this reason, some organizations track and report on animal agriculture subsidies and disseminate this information to the media, public, politicians, and funders. For example, Agriculture Fairness Alliance (AFA) and Environmental Working Group (EWG) both track U.S. animal agriculture subsidies. For advocates newly considering this type of work, note that efforts like this will benefit from having a solid communications person or team that can develop relationships with reporters and other influential individuals.

Part of educating people about farm subsidies is shifting the narrative around food and agriculture. For instance, one organization is focused on a long-term strategy of changing the public's awareness of the U.S. Farm Bill and how they think about it. The hope is that with a public narrative shift over time, greater structural reforms can be achieved in the 2028 Farm Bill: "We talk a lot about the Farm Bill as the Food and Farm Bill. I mean, it touches all Americans and it's not just something that only people in ag states should be engaging on." While there can be a lot for organizations and local advocates to learn about the Farm Bill, some organizations offer toolkits or other educational resources.

In addition to the general public, some organizations are also working to educate politicians about farm subsidies and related issues. Interviewees said that progressive candidates in particular tend to represent more urban areas and may thus not feel knowledgeable on agricultural issues. Helping progressive candidates feel more comfortable talking about agricultural policies is a key goal of this educational work.

Other Tactics

There are other ways to pressure the government to reform the food system or subsidies to animal agriculture, from public pressure campaigns–like petitions, open letters, and briefs to the government–to advocacy organizations giving feedback to government budget proposals.

Regardless of the tactics they choose, advocates should weigh the time and resource commitment of a particular action against its potential benefits and risks. Some tactics are time-consuming or resource-intensive, while some may provide inadvertent competition for similar tactics by other animal advocacy or environmental groups, harming both efforts. As with all tactics described above, we recommend that advocates conduct research ahead of time to identify other groups working in the same space. Coordination and cooperation are some of the best tools we have to make progress on any of these goals using any of these tactics.

Conclusions

Our goal with this study was to talk to advocates who work against the intense subsidization of animal agriculture to share lessons learned and see which approaches tend to be most successful.

Throughout our interviews it became clear that organizations don't simply try to reduce or eliminate animal agriculture subsidies altogether due to the immense political influence of Big Ag and the complexity of subsidies. For one, Big Ag has spent at least $200 million USD in lobbying the U.S government since 2000, and our interviewees noted that some politicians have economic ties to agribusiness. Second, subsidies to animal agriculture are wide-ranging, spanning everything from government loans (direct subsidies) to Big Ag relying on practices that reduce costs by harming human and non-human animals (indirect subsidies).

Addressing these complexities all at once isn't feasible for a single organization, so we suggest that advocates pick a specific and realistic goal and engage in strong coordination with other groups rather than trying to meet multiple objectives.

Organizations we interviewed have focused on more tractable goals instead of trying to get rid of subsidies altogether, using a variety of methods or 'ingredients' to achieve them. Below we summarize these goals and tactics (see also Figure 1 in *Background*). We recommend that advocacy organizations work together and discuss with each other which group is best suited to tackle what goal. In fact, this is similar to what Big Ag does—they have different interest and lobbying groups that work to promote and protect specific animal agriculture industries (e.g., National Pork Producers Council in the U.S).

Direct Subsidies

Before getting into specific goals of tackling direct subsidies, we wanted to point out that most people—even farmers and animal advocates—don't have a strong understanding of how farming subsidies work and how they impact the food system. For this reason, some organizations currently focus on just tracking and reporting farm subsidies. Advocates can also use this information to persuade the government to reform subsidies: For instance, data demonstrating that most subsidies go to major corporations rather than small farmers may be helpful to encourage a shift from supporting factory farming to less intensive forms of animal agriculture and plant-based agriculture.

Understanding the needs and values of multiple stakeholders is crucial to political work. Advocates should establish connections with environmental advocates, social justice advocates, and small farmers to understand their needs. Working together on joint policy initiatives is

helpful to ensure that one group's interests are not marginalized in favor of others'. For example, AFA, a U.S. vegan-backed lobbying group, has drafted a piece of legislation that will publicly fund farmers to transition from animal agriculture to plant-based agriculture, in addition to advocating for loans and grants to be more accessible to farmers who are Black, Indigenous, or of the Global Majority.

When it comes to lobbying specifically, advocates we interviewed indicated that constituents are more impactful than professional lobbyists in getting politicians to hear and support advocates' asks. In contrast, professional lobbyists are better-versed in politics, which makes them better able to amend legislation and support or write new pieces of legislation. Regardless of what kind of lobbying you use, you'll be more effective if you can develop relationships with politicians across the political spectrum.

Advocates can also work to expand funding and tax exemptions to include alternative proteins, rather than trying to shift subsidies away from Big Ag. Alternative protein organizations we spoke to said that Big Ag companies are less likely to collaborate with advocates who are trying to reduce subsidies that benefit animal agriculture, so working with Big Ag companies is the most viable way to increase their chances of funding. Without the cooperation of meat companies, alternative protein companies would have a harder time negotiating with policymakers, and also potentially face retaliation from Big Ag.

Other advocates may choose to focus on procurement: getting the government to buy more plant-based foods and offering plant-based meals in government-supported institutions like hospitals and schools. Farmed animal producers may currently be incentivized to overproduce animal products because excess food is bought by the government—one of the largest purchasers of agriculture products. Organizations we interviewed tended to use environmental and diet inclusivity arguments to advocate for plant-based food procurement policies, though these may work better for more liberal governments.

Indirect Subsidies

Advocates can also target indirect subsidies—the costs that Big Ag gets away with—like environmental pollution, anti-competitive conduct, and poor farmed animal welfare.

Advocates can use litigation to not only enforce environmental and antitrust laws for Big Ag companies, but also to obtain media and lobbying opportunities. When pursuing litigation against a company, organizations or plaintiffs must notify companies with a "notice of suit," and such notices can lead to media interviews, meetings with politicians, and eventually, legislative changes—even without having to go through the actual lawsuit. Indeed, lawsuits are costly and timely, so advocates can strategize how to maximize the impact of a notice of suit to bring awareness and potential legislative changes for a particular issue.

In some countries like Brazil (at the time of writing, before the 2022 election), reforming Big Ag subsidies may not be politically feasible, even using the non-confrontational approaches discussed above. Advocates in these countries may instead want to focus on cage-free campaigns to increase the cost of animal products by reducing animal suffering. Organizations we interviewed have had success in getting egg producers to transition to cage-free housing after establishing trust with them.

Future Research

Our interviewees also highlighted areas that are worthy of future investigation to help reform animal agriculture subsidies. One of these is looking at fossil fuel subsidy reforms as a template for a successful approach.

Like the agriculture industry, fossil fuels receive over $500 billion USD a year worldwide in direct subsidies, with most subsidies going to the oil and gas sectors (International Institute for Sustainable Development, 2020). Similar to Big Ag, Big Oil has immense political influence through lobbying. And like animal agriculture, the oil and gas sectors are large contributors to global greenhouse gas emissions, representing 56% of total emissions (International Energy Agency, 2021).

Despite these similarities, there have been international efforts to reduce oil and gas subsidies, whereas efforts to reduce animal agriculture subsidies are much newer and more limited. For instance, the United Nations Development Programme (2021) has published reports and toolkits to help advocates reform fossil fuel subsidies around the world. Such frameworks could be adapted by animal advocacy organizations to reform animal agriculture subsidies.

Caveats & Limitations

As with all studies, this one has a few limitations to bear in mind.

First, the opinions reflected throughout this report are just that, the opinions and experiences of those interviewed. To ensure that we included a range of perspectives, we included several organizations with missions not focusing on animal protection in this study, and are grateful to them for their participation. A key theme from our interviews was the importance of stakeholder collaboration—reforming agriculture subsidies will involve and impact environmental and farmed animal agriculture groups too.

Further, our report focuses on goals and strategies that were only used by the organizations we interviewed and consequently, doesn't provide a comprehensive list of subsidy reform strategies. Others include reducing fisheries' subsidies and promoting subsidies that help farmed animal producers transition to higher-welfare systems. We recommend that advocates read Animal Ask's (2022) detailed report on these topics.

As with most qualitative research, another limitation of this study is the generalizability of the goals and strategies used by the organizations we interviewed. Although we tried our best to include organizations from different countries, we were unfortunately unable to get interviews with any organizations working against subsidies in the EU. As a result, most organizations that agreed to be interviewed by us were from the U.S. However, many of the goals and tactics mentioned in our report should be valuable to advocates from different countries, unless otherwise specified.

Supplementary Materials

Method Details

Pre-Registration

In accordance with best practices, this study was pre-registered with the Open Science Framework before the coders reviewed the data. The pre-registration detailed the study design and analysis plan.

Data Collection

A total of 14 interviews with 15 advocates, lasting 30 to 60 minutes, were conducted between May and July 2022 over Zoom. Interviews were audio-recorded and transcribed. Transcriptions were coded using a thematic analysis procedure, outlined below.

Thematic Content Coding

The coding team (including the principal investigator and a reviewer) developed a coding scheme using inductive coding, in which code categories were generated based on reading and interpreting the underlying conceptual meaning of the data.

The process of developing the coding scheme and coding the data were as followed:

1. Both members of the coding team read all of the interview transcripts to get an initial feel or impression of the data. No inductive codes were created during this step.
2. The principal investigator coded three of the transcripts and generated an initial set of inductive code categories that captured the meaning of the comments.
3. The reviewer assessed the principal investigator's inductive codes: how they defined the categories, which categories they used for each interview, and where. Through this discussion, minor changes were made to the code categories.
4. The principal investigator coded an additional three interviews at a time, each time checking in with the reviewer about any changes to the coding scheme after each set, using the same process as above.
5. Once all interviews were coded, the principal investigator reread all of the transcripts and made final adjustments to the codes.